Haoyu and Rex

Where Winds Meet headcanon

A fun little love story

From the first rehearsal to an invitation home

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01 The first rehearsal

Heka had promised that they would only be stopping by for a short while. Haoyu should have known better than to attach any particular meaning to that. She had paused twice on their way through the hall to speak to someone, once to straighten a crooked ornament, and once to wave at Baoyu, who had immediately lost his place in the rehearsal.

“Please do not distract the performers,” Fae called from her table.

“I was being supportive.”

“Be supportive from over there.”

Heka accepted this with perfect cheer and guided Haoyu toward the side of the room. Fae was surrounded by notes and looked as though she could account for every lantern, musician, and spec of dust in the building. Heka had described her as both the owner of the company and the person who kept the Wet Noodles from wandering off in six different directions. Haoyu could already see that the second responsibility required considerable effort.

He set down the small parcel he had brought for Heka and turned toward the rehearsal floor just as the musicians began again.

That was when he properly noticed Rex.

At first, Haoyu watched the whole group. He had come with Heka, and he knew Baoyu and DFBB, and it would have been perfectly natural to follow their movements. Somehow his attention kept returning to the man with the pale, smoky hair, whose expression changed entirely when he found the rhythm. Rex moved with an assurance that made even an unfinished rehearsal look worth watching. Then someone missed a cue, the formation broke, and he laughed.

Haoyu forgot to look anywhere else.

Beside him, Heka followed the direction of his gaze. She said nothing. When the musicians stopped and Rex pushed a loose strand of hair away from his face, however, she glanced at her brother with a small, private smile.

“Would you like to meet everyone?”

Haoyu looked at her too quickly. “I know some of them.”

“Then the introductions will be very quick. You’ll be moving into the guild estate soon enough. Best start learning names and faces.”

He was still trying to decide whether that meant she had noticed when she took

him by the sleeve and brought him forward.

Rex was reaching for water when Heka called his name. There was a little colour in his face from the rehearsal, and his hair had escaped his attempt at styling near one temple. He turned toward them with an easy smile.

“This is my brother, Haoyu.”“Hello,” Rex said. “It’s good to finally meet you.”

For a brief, unfortunate moment, Haoyu forgot how to answer a greeting.

“You too,” he managed. “I mean—it’s good to meet you.”

Rex did not seem to find anything wrong with this. “Did you see much of the rehearsal?”

“Yes.” Haoyu paused, aware that this was not much of an answer. “You were very good.”

“Even the part where we all tried to stand in the same place?”

“I assumed that was a form of controlled chaos.”

Rex laughed, and Haoyu felt an alarming amount of relief.

“Chaos that I’m sure will be discussed at length,” Rex said, with a glance toward Fae.

Heka had stepped away to speak to DFBB. Haoyu noticed her absence only when Rex asked him about his work, and he realised there was nobody beside him to carry the conversation. He explained that he practised medicine, that he had been helping at a village clinic on the outskirts of the city, and that Heka had persuaded him to come along that afternoon.

Rex listened. It ought to have been an ordinary courtesy. Haoyu nevertheless found himself remembering where Rex rested his cup and the way he inclined his head when something interested him.

Before they could speak much longer, Fae called everyone back into position.

“Will you stay for the next run?” Rex asked.

Haoyu glanced toward Heka. She was standing beside the door with the unmistakable expression of someone who had no urgent plans at all.

“I think so,” he said.

“Good.” Rex smiled once more before returning to the others. “Always better to get immediate audience feedback.”

On their way home, Heka talked about the rehearsal, the preparations, and several things Fae wanted arranged. Haoyu answered when an answer was required. Otherwise, he walked beside her in a silence that was much less discreet than he hoped.

Eventually, Heka bumped her shoulder lightly against his.

“You enjoyed yourself.”

Haoyu looked down the path. “They were very good.”

“Yes,” she agreed, and allowed him to keep the rest to himself.

That night, he found he could remember very little of the music. Rex’s laugh, however, remained wonderfully clear.

Side Note since time will be skipped

Haoyu soon tagged along with Heka occasionally and slowly came to know everyone else in her guild which he suddenly found himself adopted into. The guild estate was vast and he was given his own small courtyard to live in so he could be close to his sister. While he was still committed to running the small village clinic, it was nice to have a home with his sister just a few courtyards

away. He was often busy with his own professional duties to take part in many of the guild's events, but he spared time when he could.

His crush on Rex would continue to grow. Haoyu always knew he was attracted to men, but for the first time he found himself very shy and awkward.

And thus a haphazard plan formed....

02 Quiet offerings

Haoyu began with food because it was something he knew would be accepted.

People who worked hard ought to eat. People who spent hours rehearsing often forgot to do so until they were already tired and disagreeable. There was nothing particularly alarming about arriving with a meal, especially when Heka gave him so many perfectly reasonable excuses to visit.

The first time, he brought a dish he had learned Rex liked and a small jar of berry wine. He checked the covering twice on the way, worried that the food might cool before rehearsal ended. By the time he reached the hall, he had rehearsed several possible explanations and disliked every one of them.

Rex looked delighted.

“For me?”

Haoyu nodded, suddenly unable to remember why this had seemed so complicated.

“You didn’t have to do that.”

“I was nearby.”

He had not been particularly nearby. His route had involved a considerable detour, but Rex was already uncovering the dish, and Haoyu decided that a detailed account of the journey would help nobody.

Baoyu mentioned that Haoyu had come to collect Heka. DFBB asked whether there was enough food for Rex to survive the evening. Rex informed him that there would be, provided nobody else became interested in it.

Haoyu stood by the table, wondering if he could sneak away before anyone could question him.

Then Rex thanked him with the comfortable warmth he offered everyone, and Haoyu went home uncertain whether he had accomplished anything at all.

The next offering was smaller. He left a wrapped snack where Rex would find it after rehearsal and intended to slip away before anyone noticed. Unfortunately,

Rex came through the door while Haoyu was still trying to make the parcel sit neatly beside his cup.

For a moment, they looked at each other.

“Were you leaving that for me?” Rex asked.

Haoyu straightened. “Yes.”

“You could have stayed.”

“I didn’t want to interrupt.”

“You’re not interrupting anything.” Rex picked up the parcel. “Except possibly my becoming unbearable from hunger.”

Haoyu laughed, because Rex was looking at him expectantly and because he was relieved to have something to do besides blush. He stayed long enough to hear about the rehearsal. When Rex thanked him again, Haoyu carried the words home as carefully as he had carried the food there.

In his own rooms, hidden from casual visitors, he had begun keeping a small collection of notes. At the top he had written, with a resolve he could rarely summon in Rex’s presence, Plan to Woo Rex. Beneath it were practical reminders: things Rex liked, days when rehearsals ran late, possible reasons to speak to him for longer than the time it took to hand over a parcel.

Haoyu had treated much more difficult problems than this at his clinic. None had involved wondering whether a compliment had sounded too much like a medical observation.

The food continued. Sometimes it was a full meal; sometimes a snack, small enough to tuck out of the way. Haoyu learned which things Rex reached for first and which he saved until last. He learned that Rex could make a tired room laugh and that, away from the centre of everyone’s attention, he sometimes grew pleasantly quiet.

Rex, meanwhile, learned to look forward to the parcels.

The discovery that they were meant only for him came one evening when he asked whether the others had already received theirs. Haoyu had already left by then. Soul looked up from the bench where he was resting, and Gong stopped folding a length of fabric.

“Their what?” Soul asked.

“Food.” Rex indicated the parcel in his hand. “From Haoyu.”

Gong looked at Soul. Soul looked at Gong.

“He doesn’t bring those for us,” Gong said.

Rex glanced toward Baoyu and DFBB, as though Heka’s husbands might somehow explain the situation. Neither supplied a different answer.

“Oh,” Rex said.

He looked genuinely touched. That, for a few promising seconds, gave Soul hope.

“He’s very kind,” Rex continued. “He must really be a devoted fan.”

Gong lowered his face over the fabric.

Soul took a slow drink of water.

Rex, occupied with the rather lovely idea that somebody had paid such particular attention to his preferences, noticed neither of them struggling.

“Should we tell him?” Gong asked quietly when Rex wandered away.

Soul watched him go. Rex had unwrapped the food with great care and was looking unusually pleased with himself.

“I want to see how long this takes.”

They shared a brief, disbelieving laugh..

When Haoyu returned the next time, Rex thanked him more warmly than ever. He said it meant a great deal to have such sincere support. Haoyu smiled and replied that he was glad.

Later, alone in his room, he sat in front of his notes for a long while before writing anything new.

03 When doubt set in

The trouble was that Rex never gave Haoyu a reason to stop hoping.

He smiled when Haoyu arrived. He remembered where their conversations had ended and picked them up again, sometimes before Haoyu had properly sat down. Once, when a rehearsal ran late, he had spotted Haoyu waiting near the doorway and waved him closer with such immediate pleasure that Haoyu had thought about it all the way home.

Those were the moments that made the second part of his plan seem sensible. He wanted Rex to know him, to feel comfortable with him, to have reasons to seek his company beyond whatever happened to be wrapped in a food parcel.

Lately, however, Haoyu had begun to wonder whether he was building exactly the friendship Rex thought they already had.

That evening, he found Rex seated beneath a lamp, attempting to free a fastening caught in his hair. Every adjustment seemed to make matters worse.

“I think I may have to sleep in it,” Rex said when he noticed him.

Haoyu set down his things. “May I?”

Rex turned obligingly, lowering his head so Haoyu could see. “If you manage it, I shall be deeply grateful.”

It took very little effort. Haoyu loosened the damaged cord and carefully worked the trapped strands free, conscious of Rex sitting patiently within reach. There was something disarming about being trusted with such an ordinary task. Haoyu wished he could enjoy it without wondering whether it meant anything.

“There.” He placed the ornament in Rex’s hand. “The cord is fraying. It needs replacing.”

“You’ve saved me from a very uncomfortable night.”

“I would hate to deprive everyone of your complaints tomorrow.”

Rex laughed, looking up at him. “You’ve become rather bold.”

“Only with sufficient encouragement.”

Haoyu managed to hold his gaze for a moment before attending to the cord again. Rex remained beside him, talking about rehearsal while Haoyu fitted a new length through the fastening. It was easy company. That was part of the difficulty.

When Rex fell quiet, Haoyu gathered his courage.

“The tea stall by the river has opened again,” he said. “The one you mentioned wanting to try.”

“Has it?”

“I passed it yesterday.” Haoyu kept his attention on the knot. “If you have a free afternoon, I could take you.”

“I’d like that.”

Haoyu’s fingers paused.

Then Rex continued, “Soul has been complaining that we never go anywhere except rehearsal and home. I’ll see whether the others are free.”

Haoyu looked down before his expression could betray him.

“Of course.”

“We could make an afternoon of it.” Rex took the ornament when Haoyu offered it back, inspecting the repaired fastening. “You’ll come as well, won’t you?”

“That was rather the idea.”

Rex laughed again, apparently hearing only the teasing in his voice.

“Good.”

Haoyu stayed a little longer. He listened, answered, even made Rex laugh once more. When he finally gathered his things, Rex thanked him warmly and reminded him about the tea.

There had been nothing unkind in any of it.

On the road home, that was what Haoyu kept returning to.

He had asked Rex to go somewhere with him. Rex had liked the suggestion. Then, quite naturally, he had imagined their friends coming too.

Perhaps Haoyu should have explained. A few simple words would have done it: *I meant just the two of us.*

Instead, he had smiled and agreed, preserving the comfortable moment at the cost of learning anything from it.

By the time he reached his courtyard he was tired from rehashing the conversation.

He set his medicine bag down and stood for a while before the little board he kept out of sight of visitors. The second part of his plan was written there in his own careful hand.

Become reliable.

He had thought it would help Rex see that his interest lasted beyond a handsome face and an entertaining afternoon. He wanted to be someone Rex could turn to when rehearsal was difficult, when he was tired, when he simply wanted company.

Now Haoyu wondered whether he had become so useful that his presence required very little thought.

The thought embarrassed him. Rex had never demanded these things. Haoyu had offered them gladly, and he still meant every kindness.

But he wanted to be invited somewhere without first suggesting it. He wanted Rex to wonder what he might enjoy. Sometimes he wanted to arrive empty-handed and be certain that his company would have been enough.

Rex might already feel that way. Haoyu could remember moments that suggested he did.

He could also remember how readily he had turned those moments into reassurance.

Haoyu sat down before the board, opened his ink pot, and considered adding another addendum to the plan.

Nothing he thought of seemed particularly useful.

Eventually, he closed the ink pot again.

The following afternoon, the clinic was busy enough that Haoyu had little opportunity to think about rehearsal.

A child accompanying his grandmother spent much of their visit folding a scrap of paper into something with two uneven wings. When Haoyu admired it, the boy informed him that it was a crane and chose a place for it on the windowsill.

“It should be able to see outside,” he explained.

Haoyu agreed solemnly and moved a jar to make room.

By late afternoon, he had answered the last of the grandmother’s questions, put away several deliveries, and discovered that his tea had gone cold twice. There was still a page of notes to finish. Usually, he would have hurried through them, calculating whether he could reach the rehearsal hall before everyone left.

Today, he pulled his stool closer to the table.

He was halfway through a sentence when someone knocked against the doorframe.

“Are you still taking patients?”

The man standing outside held a folded cloth against his palm. He was unfamiliar to Haoyu, dressed in practical robes with a scattering of pale wood shavings clinging to one sleeve.

“Yes. Come in.”

The stranger approached with an apologetic smile. “I was told this was the place to come.”

“Sit down and let me see.”

The cut was small. While Haoyu attended to it, the man explained that he had been repairing a window frame and discovered, rather abruptly, where its previous owner had left a broken piece of metal.

“A useful introduction to the house,” he said. “Although I would have preferred a less personal one.”

Haoyu smiled.

“You’ve just moved here?”

“Three days ago. Shen Huai’an.” He inclined his head towards the lane. “I’ve taken the house and workshop near the mill.”

“The farrier?”

“That was the intention. I’m hoping this won’t be the first thing everyone hears about me.”

“I make no promises. News travels very quickly here.”

Huai’an laughed, and Haoyu found himself laughing with him.

There was something restful about the conversation. His hands knew their work, the questions were straightforward, and he had no particular reason to wonder what impression he was making.

When he finished, Huai'an flexed his fingers cautiously and thanked him.

"I'm Haoyu," he said, reaching for a clean cloth to wipe the table.

"I know."

Haoyu glanced up.

"The woman who sent me here told me." Huai'an's smile warmed. "She was quite firm that I should find you before attempting anything foolish on my own."

"That sounds like several people."

"She also told me you would say that."

Haoyu shook his head, amused, and put the cloth aside.

Huai'an paid the fee, but instead of leaving immediately, he looked around the little room. His gaze passed over the shelves, the drying herbs, and the crooked bird in the window.

"Have you been here long?"

"Longer than I originally intended."

"What made you stay?"

"There was work to do." Haoyu considered how to explain it. "At first, I kept telling myself I would leave once a few people were better. Then there were other people. Eventually, it began to seem foolish to pretend I was only passing through."

"Do you like it?"

The question made Haoyu pause. "Yes," he said. "I do."

Huai'an nodded, apparently satisfied with the answer, and asked about the village. Haoyu found himself describing the market days, the neighbours who would know where to find almost anything, and which path became unpleasant after rain. Huai'an listened with an attention that made it easy to continue.

Only when someone passed outside calling a child home did Haoyu realize how late it had become.

“I’ve kept you,” Huai’an said.

“I didn’t mind.”

“Neither did I.”

The answer was simple enough that Haoyu smiled before thinking about it.

As Huai’an stood, his gaze caught on the cupboard beside the medicine shelves.

“That door sits badly.”

“It has since I arrived.”

“Mind if I take a look?”

Haoyu stepped aside. Huai’an examined the hinge without touching it, then straightened.

“I can put that right once this hand is less inconvenient.”

“You needn’t trouble yourself.”

“It’s a short walk from the workshop.” He glanced back at Haoyu. “And I would be glad to stop by again under better circumstances.”

“Preferably with both hands intact.”

“I’ll do my best.”

Haoyu walked him to the door. They exchanged farewells, and Huai’an set off towards the mill, turning briefly to lift his uninjured hand before rounding the corner.

Inside, the unfinished notes were still waiting. Haoyu sat down, drew them closer, and found himself smiling at the memory of their conversation.

His doubts about Rex remained. He would probably think about the invitation to tea again before the night was over.

For now, though, someone had asked about his work, listened to his answers, and seemed pleased by the prospect of seeing him again. Haoyu let himself enjoy that small kindness without trying to decide what might come of it.

A few days later, they met again outside the clinic. Haoyu had his arms full, and Huai'an took the topmost bundle when it began to slip. He carried it to the door, asked how the afternoon had gone, and remained to hear the answer.

Their conversations became easy. Huai'an asked about Haoyu's work, remembered things he had mentioned, and came back with questions that showed he had listened. When they walked through the village together, Haoyu did not have to search for a reason to prolong the conversation.

He appreciated it more than he had expected.

There was relief in being sought out. After weeks of carefully arranging chances to stand beside Rex, it was pleasant to open the clinic door and find somebody who had come specifically to see him.

Yet it was still Rex whose name caught his attention across a room. It was Rex he thought of when he passed a stall selling something he liked, and Rex whose absence he felt when he had chosen not to attend a rehearsal.

One evening, Huai'an offered to walk with him as far as the bridge. Haoyu agreed, glad of the company after a long day. They stopped beside the water while Huai'an told him about another minor disaster in the business of settling into a new home.

Later, he would remember how ordinary that evening had felt to him. A friend, a quiet conversation, the first unhurried part of a busy day.

04 Where his heart remained

Shen Huai'an had been in the village for a little over a month when Haoyu began to suspect that his visits to the clinic had very little to do with the cut on his palm.

That had healed some time ago. Since then, there had been the straightened door, a repaired cupboard hinge, a handful of early pears, and several conversations that began with a perfectly reasonable question and wandered pleasantly into the afternoon. Huai'an had an easy smile and a patient way of listening. He remembered things Haoyu told him.

It was nice to be remembered.

Haoyu enjoyed his company. When he saw the farrier approaching through the market that afternoon, he smiled and slowed his steps, shifting his basket to make room beside him on the narrow path.

"Finished for the day?" Huai'an asked.

"Buying things, yes. Working, unfortunately not."

"Then I shall try not to keep you too long." Huai'an saw Haoyu struggling with his shopping load and moved to take a basket from him. "Here, let me help you with that."

"That's really not – " Haoyu could scarcely finish his objection before the basket was taken from where he balanced it on his hip. "Thank you."

They walked together past the last few stalls, talking about the house Huai'an was repairing for himself near the mill. The roof was finally sound, he said, although the swallows appeared to consider the eaves their property and objected whenever he went near them.

"You did move into their house," Haoyu pointed out.

"So I've been told. Loudly."

Haoyu laughed. Beside him, Huai'an smiled, then grew quiet as they reached the little bridge. Haoyu took back his basket so as to continue on his way…

"Haoyu," he said, "there is something I've been meaning to ask you."

Something in his manner made Haoyu stop.

Huai'an rested a hand on the railing. He was usually so comfortable in conversation that the care with which he chose his next words was unmistakable.

"I've enjoyed getting to know you. More than I expected when I first came here." He glanced briefly towards the water, then met Haoyu's eyes. "I would like to court you, if you would welcome it."

For a moment, Haoyu heard only the stream beneath the bridge.

He had noticed the attention. He had been pleased by it, too—the small kindnesses, the interest in his day, the warmth that entered Huai'an's expression whenever they met. It had made his long afternoons feel less solitary.

But now that the question had been asked, the answer was painfully clear.

He looked down at the basket in his hands.

Huai'an waited.

"I'm glad you told me," Haoyu said at last. "And I'm sorry. I can't return your feelings."

Huai'an's fingers tightened briefly against the railing before relaxing.

"There's someone?"

"Yes."

Haoyu lifted his gaze. Huai'an deserved to hear it plainly.

"My heart is already with someone else."

The words felt strangely different spoken aloud. He had carried them through so many ordinary days, tucked into meals prepared after work and journeys made when he ought to have been resting. Saying them here, to someone who had offered him something kind, left him feeling both certain and terribly exposed.

Huai'an nodded slowly.

"I wondered," he admitted. "Sometimes you look towards the road when someone passes the clinic."

Haoyu's face warmed.

"I didn't realize."

"I thought perhaps you were expecting a patient." A small, rueful smile touched Huai'an's mouth. "Eventually, I began to hope you might look that way for me."

Haoyu wished there were an answer that would make this easier without making it less honest.

"I'm sorry," he said again.

"You haven't wronged me by caring for someone."

They stood quietly for a little while. A cart rattled along the lane behind them, and both stepped closer to the railing to let it pass.

"Does he know?" Huai'an asked when it had gone.

Haoyu considered the question.

"I've never told him directly."

"Ah."

"I thought I was being quite obvious." Despite himself, Haoyu smiled faintly. "I'm beginning to suspect we have very different ideas about what obvious means."

Huai'an gave a soft breath of laughter, though the disappointment remained in his face.

“And you want to wait for him?”

“I want to speak to him properly.” Haoyu rubbed his thumb over the basket handle. “I don’t know what he’ll say. But I know I couldn’t begin something with you while wishing it were him.”

Huai’an looked at him for a moment, then nodded.

“Thank you for being clear.”

Haoyu let out a slow breath.

“There is something else I hope you’ll believe,” he said. “I’ve enjoyed your company. That wasn’t politeness. I like hearing about your house and your unreasonable swallows. I would be sorry to lose your friendship.”

The farrier’s expression softened a little.

“I’d like us to remain friends,” Haoyu continued. “If that’s something you would want, too.”

Huai’an looked down at the stream.

“I think it is,” he said eventually. “Although I might need a little time before I can sit across from you over tea without feeling rather foolish.”

“You weren’t foolish.”

“I know.” His smile returned, small but real. “Knowing may take a little while to help.”

Haoyu nodded. He understood that well enough.

“Then take the time you need.”

“I’ll see you around, Haoyu.”

“I hope so.”

Huai’an inclined his head and took the path towards home. Haoyu watched him go for a moment before continuing towards the clinic.

He felt sad for the disappointment he had caused, even though he knew there had been no kinder answer. He hoped Huai'an would come for tea again someday. He hoped they would eventually be able to laugh about the swallows without either of them remembering the bridge quite so sharply.

When Haoyu reached the clinic, he set down his basket and opened the shutters to let in the last of the afternoon light. Through the window, he could see the road leading into the village.

His eyes followed it before he caught himself.

He rested his hands on the sill, a little embarrassed by how well Huai'an had understood him.

The next time he saw Rex, he thought, he would try to be braver. Huai'an had deserved an honest answer. Perhaps Rex deserved the chance to give him one.

Later, after closing the clinic Haoyu set off towards home. As he walked back toward the estate, he felt sad for having disappointed someone he liked, and grateful that Huai'an had trusted him enough to speak plainly.

He thought, too, of how plainly he had answered.

There was someone else. Saying it had not made his feelings less complicated, but it had made them impossible to dismiss as a passing admiration he might eventually grow out of.

When he reached his courtyard, he put away the notes he had been keeping. He did not tear them up. He simply folded them and placed them where he did not have to look at them every evening.

He still wanted Rex. He was just beginning to accept that wanting him could not be the only thing he did with his days.

05 What Rex had missed

Several evenings before Huai'an spoke to Haoyu at the bridge, Rex noticed the empty doorway before he admitted to noticing Haoyu's absence.

Rehearsal had ended in its usual untidy fashion. Someone asked where they were eating, someone else complained about a step that had been changed again, and Rex glanced towards the entrance with the comfortable expectation that had formed over the past several weeks. Sometimes Haoyu was there with Heka. Sometimes he arrived alone, carrying something wrapped in cloth and looking as though he hoped nobody would make much of it. He usually waited until Rex caught his eye before approaching, although his smile tended to give him away well before then.

Tonight, once again, there was nobody.

Rex took his time gathering his things. He adjusted the tie at his wrist, drank the last of his tea, and lingered near the entrance while the musicians packed away their instruments. When Soul called to ask whether he was coming, Rex said yes and followed the others out. There was no reason to stay, and he felt faintly foolish for having needed someone to remind him.

It happened again two evenings later. This time, he caught himself looking before rehearsal had even finished.

Haoyu was busy, Rex told himself. The clinic mattered to him, and people did not stop needing help simply because the Wet Noodles had reached the end of their practice. There had been evenings when Haoyu arrived late and apologised, explaining that a patient had needed more time. Rex had always assured him that it was fine. He had never meant for Haoyu to feel obliged to come.

Knowing all of that did very little to explain why Rex kept looking towards the door.

The following morning, Rex left the estate to accompany an old acquaintance to the ferry.

A trader friend of his had sent word two days earlier. There had been trouble along that stretch of road, and he would appreciate the company while transporting his goods to the crossing. Rex had known him since a winter when the man had shared his supper without asking why Rex could not afford his own. They agreed to meet shortly after sunrise at the city gates.

They set off on schedule and by the time they reached the river, Rex had dealt with two men demanding payment to use a public road, helped retrieve a mule that had taken exception to the proceedings, and listened to a lengthy account of why the trader's nephew could no longer be trusted to purchase rope.

The mule had occupied considerably more of his morning than the men.

Rex was still finding tufts of grass caught in his clothes when the ferry departed. Watching it pull away, he began deciding how he would explain that part to Haoyu. There was a particular expression Haoyu wore when he suspected Rex had omitted something important. Rex could already imagine it appearing when he reached the moment where he had climbed down the bank.

He smiled to himself, then grew quiet.

He had thought of Haoyu several times that morning. Once when the trader offered him something to eat, and again when they passed a stand of flowering plants he couldn't name. Now he had an entire story ready, but had no idea when he would have the chance to tell it.

Haoyu had been busy lately. Rex understood that. He had never expected him to arrange his days around Rex's schedule.

Still, as he took the road back towards the village outside the city gates, he found himself hoping they might meet.

Passing down the market street that leads into the city, he saw Haoyu with another man near a market stall.

Haoyu was holding a basket against his hip while his companion spoke. The man had rolled his sleeves to his elbows and carried a parcel beneath one arm.

Whatever he was saying made Haoyu laugh, his face turning towards him with an ease Rex had not often seen when they were together.

Before Rex could call out, the stranger reached for the basket. Haoyu began to object, but the man had already taken its weight. Haoyu thanked him, and they continued through the market together, and Rex found himself watching them go.

He could have caught up. Instead, he continued along the road.

It would have been intrusive to interrupt. Rex repeated that to himself with considerable determination. A reasonable conclusion even.

Haoyu was of course allowed to have friends that were unknown to the rest of the guild. Friends that Rex did not know. And he was allowed to enjoy an afternoon in the village and let someone carry his shopping. None of those things required an explanation.

By the time Rex reached the estate, he was uncomfortably aware of several conflicting feelings. He had wanted Haoyu to notice him. Worse, he had wanted to be the reason Haoyu looked so pleased. There was no reason for Haoyu to need to do either of those things.

At rehearsal the following day, Gong had to repeat a question twice before Rex realised he was being addressed.

“Sorry,” Rex said, turning towards him. “What did you ask?”

“Whether you wanted to go through that section again,” Gong replied. He studied Rex for a moment. “Although I’m beginning to think you weren’t here for it the first time.”

“I was here.”

“Your physical presence has been a comfort,” Gong assured him. “But your spirit seems to have wandered off to places unknown.”

Rex gave him a look, but his attention drifted towards the entrance before he could think of an answer. Soul, seated on the nearby bench, followed the glance.

“Expecting someone?” Soul asked.

“No,” Rex replied, then reconsidered. “Has Haoyu been around?”

Soul looked back at him. “Have you asked him?”

“I haven’t seen him.”

“We all live on the same estate, Rex.”

“At opposite ends!”

“A formidable distance,” Gong folded his arms. “And how far did you travel just yesterday to see an old friend?”

Rex’s face made a crinkled expression of frustration which made Gong lower his eyes, although it did little to conceal his amusement. Soul shifted along the bench to make room, and after a moment Rex sat down beside him.

“You can go and see him yourself you know,” Soul said.

“I know that,” Rex answered.

“Then why haven’t you?”

Rex rested his forearms on his knees. Around them, the others were beginning to put things away, their conversations drifting through the room. He picked at the loose end of his wrist tie, aware that both Soul and Gong were waiting.

“I saw him in the village,” Rex admitted. “He was with someone.”

“A friend?” Gong asked.

“I don’t know. A man.”

Soul’s gaze settled more closely on him. “Did you speak to them?”

“They were talking,” Rex said, trying to sound reasonable.

“You’re allowed to say hello,” Soul replied.

“I know that, too.”

Gong leaned back against the edge of the practice platform. “So you didn’t speak to him when you saw him, and now you’re waiting here in the hope that he’ll come and speak to you?”

Put like that, it sounded worse than Rex had intended.

“He looked occupied,” Rex said, though the excuse felt weak even to him. He hesitated before adding, “They seemed comfortable together.”

Soul’s amusement softened. “That bothered you?”

Rex looked down at his hands. He remembered the stranger taking Haoyu’s basket, and how readily their conversation had continued afterwards. He had thought about it several times since, usually when he was trying to think about something else.

“Do you think he might be courting him?” Rex asked, his voice suddenly smaller than he was

“We have no idea,” Soul answered.

“He could be,” Gong said, more gently than Rex expected.

Rex nodded as though that were an entirely manageable possibility. Beside him, Soul let the silence settle before speaking again.

“Have you ever considered that Haoyu might have been trying to court you?”

Rex turned towards him. “I thought he just liked coming here.”

“He seemed to like seeing you,” Gong replied.

“He brings food for—” Rex stopped. He had been about to say *everyone*, although he already knew that was not true. The others sometimes stole a bite or persuaded him to share, but the parcels were handed to him. Haoyu remembered what he liked. Even when Heka brought her brother along, Haoyu usually found his way to Rex before the evening was over.

Soul watched the recognition cross his face. “We’re only telling you what we’ve noticed,” he said. “You’ll have to ask Haoyu what he means by it.”

Rex looked towards the courtyard entrance again. He thought of the meals carefully wrapped to keep them warm, and of Haoyu settling beside him to ask where he had been on his recent travels.

Haoyu remembered people Rex had mentioned only once. He asked whether a disagreement had been settled, whether an old travelling companion had recovered from an injury, whether Rex had ever returned something he had accidentally borrowed and carried halfway across the countryside. Sometimes Rex had to think for a moment before remembering which story they had been discussing.

Haoyu usually remembered where they had left it.

Rex had enjoyed that more than he had realised. He liked being able to begin with a name and see recognition in Haoyu’s face. He liked the questions, too, even when they made it difficult to leave out a less flattering part of the account.

He had started saving things to tell him.

Until that afternoon, he had scarcely considered what it meant that he wanted Haoyu, in particular, to hear them.

“He’s kind,” Rex said quietly.

“He is,” Soul agreed. “And he keeps choosing to spend his time with you.”

Across the room, Baoyu paused beside an instrument case he had been fastening shut. “Sometimes he comes straight from the clinic,” he added. “He’s tired when he gets here.”

Rex glanced towards him.

“You wouldn’t always know it once he sees you,” Baoyu continued, then lowered his attention to the case again, leaving Rex to consider that without further comment.

A particular evening came back to him. Haoyu had been sitting on the steps while Rex finished eating, his shoulder resting against a pillar and his eyes closing briefly between sentences. Rex had asked whether he was sleepy. Haoyu had smiled and said he would be all right once he started walking, then asked whether Rex wanted the last of the food.

Rex could remember taking it. He could not remember asking whether Haoyu had eaten.

“Oh,” he said.

Neither Soul nor Gong hurried to fill the silence. That almost made it harder. There was no secret they needed to reveal, no private confession they had been keeping from him. Rex had been present for every visit. He had enjoyed Haoyu’s company and even started to expect it, without giving much thought to the effort that brought him there.

“I think I just expected that he would come back,” Rex admitted.

“Maybe he will,” Soul said. “But you don’t have to wait for him to do all the walking.”

Rex rubbed a hand over his face before looking up at them. “Have I been very stupid?”

“A little,” Gong replied.

Soul nudged him with an elbow.

“A manageable amount,” Gong amended, earning a reluctant laugh from Rex.

The small joke eased some of his embarrassment, although it did nothing to settle the question that had begun troubling him. Haoyu might have wanted something more.

He still might.

Or he might have grown tired of waiting for Rex to understand. Somewhere in the village was a man who apparently had no difficulty noticing when Haoyu was carrying too much.

Soul rose when someone called his name from the courtyard, probably Mori. Before leaving, he rested a hand briefly on Rex's shoulder.

"Talk to him," Soul said. "You'll learn more from a direct approach than you will sitting here with us."

Rex stayed a little longer after the others had gone. Without the noise of rehearsal around him, he could hear someone sweeping the corridor outside and the faint clatter of dishes being carried across the courtyard. Usually, by now, he would have been unwrapping something Haoyu had brought, asking him to sit down before he hurried away again.

He had been telling himself that he missed the food. It was becoming difficult to maintain that explanation when what he wanted most was to hear Haoyu's opinion on his more recent story.

There had been a patient he was worried about. An older woman, Rex remembered, although he could not recall whether she was the one whose grandson accompanied her or the one who insisted on coming alone. He wanted to ask how she was doing. He wanted to know whether the cupboard hinge was still giving Haoyu trouble, and whether he had found time to eat before leaving the clinic.

Thinking of the stranger asking those questions brought back the same unpleasant feeling Rex had carried home from the village. He sat with it for a while. There was nothing he could reasonably dislike about a man whose only offence had been making Haoyu laugh and carrying his basket.

Haoyu deserved to have someone take an interest in his day. Rex knew that. He wanted him to be fed, listened to, and given a reason to smile when he was tired.

Rex stood up abruptly but with intention. He had no idea what Haoyu would say to an unexpected visit. He gathered his outer robe anyway.

He found Heka about to head out to where Baoyu and DFBB were waiting for her and asked her how to reach the clinic.

Heka's expression was that of someone knowing far too much. She gave him the directions without asking why, then made him repeat the turning beyond the mill because people often missed it.

"Before the narrow bridge?" Rex checked.

"After the mill, before the bridge," Heka confirmed. "Follow that lane on the left until you reach the well. You'll see the clinic from there."

"Thank you," Rex said.

"You're welcome," Heka replied.

Rex was grateful that she left it there. He had been half afraid she might tease him, and half tempted to ask whether Haoyu would be glad to see him. Neither possibility would have made walking through the clinic door any easier. That answer needed to come from Haoyu.

Had he turned around to ask her any of that, he would have seen her doing a silly excited dance.

As he walked with exceptional speed through the city, Rex changed his mind twice before settling on supper. He chose rice, ginger chicken, and pickled vegetables, asking for enough for two before worrying that Haoyu might have already eaten. He bought it anyway. If nothing else, Haoyu could keep some for later.

The sesame cakes required a trip to the stall near the big bridge. Rex remembered Haoyu mentioning them to Heka after rehearsal, affectionately complaining that she had eaten the last one he brought home. The soft ones, he had said. Rex was almost certain of that.

The stallholder was beginning to pack away when he arrived.

"Do you have any sesame cakes left?" Rex asked, only slightly out of breath as he had sprinted the final distance when he realized he might be too late.

“A few,” she answered, uncovering a tray. “You’re fortunate. I was about to leave.”

Rex looked at the remaining cakes with more relief than the purchase should reasonably have caused. “I’ll take those. Please. And thank you!”

She wrapped them while he waited. She noticed he lacked any receptacle in which to carry the small feast he was about to be juggling in his arms. Taking pity on him she offered him a spare basket, making him promise to return it the next time he came for cakes. He accepted gratefully.

As Rex continued to make his way towards the clinic his mind had begun to race with questions. Whether Haoyu had stopped visiting because he was busy, or because coming had begun to hurt. Whether the man from the market had already asked for something Rex was only now finding he perhaps wanted as well.

He followed Heka’s directions, checking the turning beyond the mill (but before the bridge) and continuing towards the well. The clinic came into view and Rex paused. In that moment he found that deciding to visit someone and knowing what to say when he arrived did not go hand in hand. He urged his feet to continue on all the same.

Through the clinic window, he could see a lamp burning and Haoyu’s head just visible from where he sat. Rex slowed for a moment, his hand tightening around the basket handle. Then Haoyu came into clearer view, sat at a table slightly hunched while writing with immense focus, and Rex found himself wondering how long he had been working without a break.

He crossed the remaining distance and knocked.

06 Supper at the clinic

The last patient had left some time ago, but Haoyu was still at the table with his ledger open. His tea had gone cold. Around him, the clinic had settled into its evening quiet: medicine drawers closed, the examination cot straightened, bundles of drying herbs stirring whenever a little air came through the window. Across the lane, someone was fastening their shutters, and the smell of supper made him aware that he had yet to think about his own.

He was finishing a note when somebody knocked.

“Come in,” Haoyu called, setting down his brush.

The latch lifted, and he looked up expecting the old woman from the end of the lane, who sometimes remembered another question halfway home. Instead, Rex stood in the doorway with a covered basket in his hand.

He wore pale, simple robes, his hair loose around his face. There was dust along his hem from the road, and an uncertainty in his expression that Haoyu was unaccustomed to seeing directed at him. For a moment, Haoyu forgot whatever welcome he had been about to offer.

“I hope this is all right,” Rex said. “I thought you might still be here.”

“Yes.” Haoyu stood too quickly, catching his sleeve against the edge of the table. He freed it with a care that only made the movement more noticeable. “Yes, of course. Is everything all right?”

Rex glanced at the basket. “I brought supper.”

Haoyu looked at it, then back at him.

“For us,” Rex added. “If you haven’t eaten.”

“I haven’t.”

“Good. I mean—”

Haoyu smiled before Rex could find a correction. “Please come in.”

Making room at the table gave them both something useful to do. Haoyu gathered his ledger and loose papers while Rex stepped inside, looking around the little room. A sheet slipped from the pile and drifted beneath the table. Rex crouched to retrieve it, placing it neatly on top of the others without comment, and Haoyu carried everything to the medicine cupboard before anything else could escape him.

By the time he returned with another bowl, Rex was unpacking the basket. There was rice, chicken fragrant with ginger, and pickled vegetables wrapped carefully to keep them warm. Then Rex placed a small paper parcel beside Haoyu's bowl and unfolded it.

Haoyu stopped with the bowls still in his hands.

"How did you…?"

"You said you liked them," Rex explained.

"The sesame cakes?"

Rex nodded. "The soft ones from the stall near the bridge."

"I was talking to Heka."

"I overheard."

Haoyu remembered the conversation. Heka had eaten the last cake he brought home, and he had been explaining why saving something for later ought to mean finding it there later. He had barely thought about it afterwards. He certainly hadn't realized Rex had been listening.

"She usually sells out before dusk," Haoyu said.

"Yes. She told me I was fortunate."

Haoyu glanced at the dust along Rex's robes. The bridge was on the other side of town. He put down the bowls and sat, taking a moment to fold back the paper so that Rex might not notice quite how much colour had risen into his face.

At first, conversation came in careful pieces. Rex asked about his day, and Haoyu explained why the village carpenter had spent part of the afternoon arguing with him over payment. Rex listened, then glanced at the mismatched stools tucked around the room.

“He made those?”

“Most of them,” Haoyu replied. “I’ve asked him to stop.”

“Has that helped?”

“He says a clinic can always use another place to sit.”

Rex looked down at the stool beneath him. “He makes a persuasive case.”

Haoyu laughed, and Rex’s shoulders eased. He took another mouthful of rice before remembering something he had been waiting to tell him.

“I went out to the ferry yesterday,” Rex said. “An old friend was taking his goods across. He’d heard there was trouble on the road and asked me to go with him.”

“Was there? Trouble I mean.”

“Two men had decided that everyone passing ought to pay them.”

Haoyu lowered his bowl slightly. “What happened?”

“They reconsidered.” Rex reached for the vegetables. “The mule was more difficult.”

“The mule?”

“It went down the bank while we were occupied.”

Haoyu studied him for a moment. “And you went after it.”

“Someone had to.”

“Of course,” Haoyu replied, although the beginnings of a smile made Rex narrow his eyes.

“You haven’t heard what happened yet.”

“I’m listening.”

Rex had imagined telling this story often enough that the beginning came easily. By the time he reached the part where his friend shouted advice at him from the safety of the road, Haoyu had set down his bowl to laugh.

“All that help from you and he wouldn’t even come down to help you?”

“He said having both of us at the bottom would accomplish very little.”

“He may have had a point.”

Haoyu was still smiling as Rex described getting the animal back onto the road. He asked questions, as Rex had known he would, and caught the omission when Rex attempted to pass too quickly over how he had lost his footing.

“You fell?”

“I sat down rather suddenly.”

“On the bank?”

“Mostly.”

Haoyu laughed again, then glanced towards Rex’s hands. “Were you hurt?”

“Only my dignity. It recovered before we reached the ferry.”

“I’m relieved to hear it.”

Rex smiled at him across the table. This was the part he had been missing: Haoyu’s amusement, his questions, the way he listened closely enough to know when something had been left out.

“I thought you’d like that story,” Rex admitted.

Haoyu’s expression softened. “I do.”

Rex then found that he forgot what he had intended to say next. Then his gaze moved to the crooked paper bird on the windowsill.

“Did someone make that for you?” Rex asked.

“A little boy who comes here with his grandmother. He told me it was a crane.”

Rex leaned sideways to inspect its rather short neck. “Of course. Unmistakable really.”

“He wanted it by the window so it could see outside. He checks whenever they come back.”

“Is she the grandmother you were worried about?” Rex asked. “You mentioned an older woman who wasn’t getting better.”

Haoyu looked back at him, surprised. “Yes. She’s doing much better now. Her grandson has appointed himself responsible for making certain she rests.”

“Does she listen to him?”

“More than she listens to me.”

Rex smiled. “Perhaps you should employ him.”

“He already expects payment whenever he visits.”

“In money?”

“Dried fruit.”

“A reasonable arrangement,” Rex said, glancing towards the paper bird again. Haoyu’s gaze followed his and also settled on the silly paper bird.

When he turned back, Rex was looking at him instead. There was a small smile on his face, and he held Haoyu’s gaze for a moment before returning to his food. Haoyu reached for his tea, only to discover that Rex had already emptied the cold dregs and refilled his cup.

For a little while, they ate without speaking. Then Rex set down his bowl.

“I saw you the other day,” he said. “I was going to come over, but you were with someone, and I didn’t want to intrude.”

Haoyu thought back, then understood.

“Shen Huai’an. He moved to the village recently.” He paused with his fingers resting against his cup. “We’re friends. Only friends.”

Rex lowered his gaze. “I wasn’t certain.”

Haoyu watched him, suddenly very conscious of how carefully Rex had said it. He had answered quickly, perhaps more quickly than he needed to, but he found that he wanted Rex to understand.

“You could have come over,” Haoyu said. “I would have liked to see you.”

Rex looked up, and some of the uncertainty left his expression.

“Then next time, I will.”

“Please do.”

They both returned their attention to the table. Rex reached for the teapot, lifted it, and discovered that both cups were still full. He put it down again.

Haoyu pressed his lips together, looking determinedly at his bowl.

“You can laugh,” Rex said.

“I wasn’t going to.”

“That’s very kind of you.”

This time, Haoyu could not prevent it. Rex laughed with him, rubbing a thumb along the handle of his cup before finally leaving it alone.

When the food was nearly finished, Rex glanced toward the open ledger on the cupboard.

“You’ve been busy.”

“A little,” Haoyu replied. “Some days more than others.”

“I kept looking for you after rehearsal.”

Haoyu’s fingers grew still.

“And yesterday, coming back from the ferry,” Rex continued. “I kept thinking about telling you what had happened.”

“I’m sorry. The clinic has been—”

“You don’t need to apologise,” Rex said quickly. He looked down at his bowl before meeting Haoyu’s eyes again. “I just realised I was waiting for you to come and find me, when I’m just as capable of coming to see you myself.”

Haoyu glanced at the basket beside the table.

“I’m glad you did.”

It was true, although it was not the whole truth. There had also been evenings when he could have finished early enough to visit and had stayed to sort supplies that did not need sorting. He had grown tired of wondering whether Rex was pleased to see him or simply pleased by whatever he had brought.

“How did you know where it was?” Haoyu asked, realizing this was in fact the first time Rex had ever been to his clinic.

“I asked Heka.” Rex glanced at him, a little embarrassed. “She gave very thorough directions.”

Haoyu smiled. He could picture his sister doing precisely that, making certain Rex could find the clinic and leaving every other question alone.

Rex looked around the room again, taking in the medicine drawers, the drying herbs, and the paper crane by the window.

“You’ve been coming all that way to see me,” he said. “I wanted to see where you spend your days. And I thought I should bring something you in particular would like.”

“You remembered the cakes.”

“I remembered a few things.”

Haoyu looked down at the parcel between them. He had imagined Rex arriving like this often enough to feel a little foolish about it, usually while packing food for another visit of his own. Now that Rex was sitting across from him, he found himself unsure of how much he could safely say out loud now.

“I liked coming to see you,” Haoyu admitted. “Even when I was busy.”

Rex’s attention settled on his face.

“I think I understand that now.”

Haoyu glanced up. Rex was still watching him, his expression gentle, and for once Haoyu did not feel obliged to explain away what he had said.

“I’m glad you came,” he told him.

“So am I.”

They took their time over the cakes. Rex asked another question about the clinic, and Haoyu found himself telling him more than he had intended: the little girl who had finally stopped hiding behind her father when she came through the door, the neighbours who claimed to dislike each other but always arrived together, the stubborn patients who returned to work before they ought to and then seemed surprised when he knew.

Rex listened to all of it. Sometimes he asked a question. Sometimes he smiled into his tea, and Haoyu realized how long it had been since he had sat down at the end of a day and told someone these things without worrying about keeping them too late or what was appropriate.

By the time they began clearing the table, the lamp had burned low. Rex insisted on helping, accepting Haoyu’s directions on where to put things with a seriousness that made him want to smile again. Soon the bowls were packed away and the table was clear, and Haoyu found himself wishing he had left something unfinished.

Rex folded the cloth over the basket, then looked up.

“Could I come again tomorrow?”

Haoyu turned toward him so quickly that Rex smiled.

“After rehearsal,” Rex added. “If that’s okay with you?”

“Yes,” Haoyu said. “Very much. I mean, I would like that.”

“I can bring supper again.”

“You don’t have to bring anything.”

Rex paused with his hands fidgeting with his sleeves. “I’ll probably bring something.”

Outside, the lane lay silver beneath the moon. Rex stepped toward the door, then stopped beneath the hanging herbs and turned back as though there were still something he wanted to say. Haoyu picked up the basket and brought it to him.

“Thank you for coming,” Haoyu said.

“I’m glad you let me stay.”

Haoyu looked down at the woven handle. “You can stay as long as you’d like. It’s quiet here. Especially in the evenings.”

The words escaped before he could make them more cautious. When he looked up, Rex’s smile had softened.

“Quiet is nice.” Rex reached for the basket. Their fingertips brushed against the handle, and for a moment neither moved. Haoyu could feel the light warmth of Rex’s fingers beside his own.

He turned his hand slightly, letting his fingertips rest against Rex’s for one brief, deliberate moment.

Rex looked down at the touch, then back at Haoyu. His fingers lingered until Haoyu gently released the handle.

“Goodnight, Haoyu.”

“Goodnight, Rex.”

When the door closed, Haoyu remained beside it with his hand still half raised, listening to Rex’s footsteps disappear down the lane.

07 Rex walks home

Rex made it as far as the next lantern before he stopped.

There was no practical reason to stop. The path was clear, the night was pleasant, and he knew perfectly well how to get home. Nevertheless, he shifted the empty basket to his other hand and looked down at his fingers.

The touch had lasted hardly any time at all.

He could still feel it.

Haoyu had not simply failed to move away. He had turned his hand. Rex remembered the small movement with an accuracy he could not have applied to any other part of the evening. His face warmed again, and he lowered his hand before somebody could come along and find him standing beneath a lantern examining his own fingertips.

He resumed walking.

You can stay as long as you'd like.

The words returned before he had taken a dozen steps. Rex looked down at the basket and smiled helplessly into the night.

He had arrived at the clinic uncertain whether he would be welcome. Rex had talked his way into unfamiliar company often enough on his travels. Usually, he could find something to say, and if the conversation went poorly, he seldom troubled himself over it for very long. Tonight, he had stood outside a familiar person's door worrying whether bringing supper might be presumptuous.

He had worried about the food, the timing, whether Haoyu might already have plans. He had wanted to tell him about the ferry, but he had also wanted to ask about his day, and somewhere between buying the cakes and reaching the clinic, even that had begun to seem difficult.

Haoyu had made room for him.

He had moved the ledger, fetched a bowl, and looked at the sesame cakes as though remembering one small preference was something remarkable. Rex wished he had been doing it for longer.

At the bridge, he slowed again. The food stall was closed, its shutters secured for the night. He found himself thinking about what else Haoyu liked and realised that, this time, he could simply ask.

There would be tomorrow.

The thought steadied him enough to make room for embarrassment. Rex remembered lifting the teapot over two perfectly full cups and closed his eyes briefly. Of all the things he might have chosen to do with his hands, he had selected the least useful.

Then he remembered Haoyu trying not to laugh, and he smiled again.

He had liked making Haoyu laugh. Yesterday, standing beside the ferry with grass still caught in his clothes, he had imagined how Haoyu would react to the story. Tonight, Haoyu had caught precisely the part Rex had hoped to pass over and made him admit to falling down the bank.

Rex smiled at the memory. He could already imagine his friend's satisfaction at discovering that someone else had found the incident equally amusing. Then he remembered Haoyu looking towards his hands and asking whether he had been hurt. Rex glanced down at them again, feeling a warmth that had very little to do with the absurdity of the mule.

He was glad he had gone to tell him.

He was glad, too, that he had stayed long enough to hear about the village carpenter, the little boy and his grandmother, and the neighbours who apparently disliked each other too much to visit the clinic separately. He had questions about those two already. He would have to ask Haoyu tomorrow.

The thought pleased him. Usually, when Rex returned from somewhere, people asked where he had been and what had happened. He enjoyed telling them. He could happily spend an evening explaining himself, especially if Soul was there to dispute the details.

Tonight, he had watched Haoyu grow more comfortable across the table and found himself reluctant to interrupt. There had been more to hear whenever he asked another question. Haoyu had a particular smile when he spoke about his patients, fond even when he described how thoroughly they ignored his advice.

Rex wanted another evening like that. He wanted to know whether the village carpenter brought another stool, whether the grandmother continued to improve, and what Haoyu might tell him once he no longer felt obliged to worry about keeping him too late.

And then he recalled, ‘Only a friend.’

Relief moved through him once more, quiet and unmistakable. He was glad he had asked without demanding an explanation. He was especially gladHaoyu had understood what he was trying to ask.

More than anything, he kept returning to the invitation hidden in the answer: ‘you could have come over. I would have liked to see you.’

For weeks, Rex had been pleased when Haoyu found him even if he didn’t consciously understand that that is what was happening. It had taken him an embarrassingly long time to further understand that he could go looking in return.

When he reached the estate, he crossed the familiar paths toward his own courtyard. Haoyu’s rooms lay at the opposite end. Somewhere behind those walls, Haoyu would eventually be going home too, perhaps thinking about the evening, perhaps already occupied with something else.

Rex hoped he was thinking about it.

In his room, he put down the basket, took two steps away, and returned to move it beside the door where he would see it in the morning.

Then he looked at his hand once more.

This time, with nobody there to see him, he allowed himself to smile for as long as he liked.

08 A sister and good advice

Haoyu arrived at Heka's door still holding the clinic key.

He had meant to go directly to his own rooms. Instead, at the turn in the walkway, he had found himself changing direction. Now he stood on the threshold while Heka looked up from the table, where Baoyu and DFBB were sitting with her. Weiyun occupied the quieter place near the lamp, a book open in her hands.

Heka took one look at her brother and stood.

"You two," she said to her husbands, "go and enjoy the courtyard."

Baoyu glanced toward the door. "It's dark."

"The moon is still there."

DFBB looked from her to Haoyu and rose without argument. Baoyu followed, pausing only to collect his cup. Neither asked for an explanation. Heka saw them out, closed the door, and turned back with an expression that was softer now that she no longer needed to arrange the room.

"Would you like Weiyun to stay or go?"

Haoyu nodded. "She can stay."

Weiyun marked her place and set the book aside.

Heka brought him to the table. "Sit down."

He sat. For a moment, she waited. Haoyu looked at the table, at Weiyun, and finally at his sister. "Rex came to the clinic."

Heka's smile appeared slowly. "Did he?"

"He brought supper."

"That was thoughtful of him." All the effort in the world couldn't contain the grin she directed to Weiyun.

Haoyu studied her face. "Did you ask him to?"

The question made her expression change. She reached across the table and touched his wrist. “No. He asked me where the clinic was. I told him.”

“That was all?” Haoyu’s voice was small as he quietly asked for reassurance.

“That was all.” She gave his wrist a gentle squeeze.

Haoyu looked down, absorbing this thoughtfully. Rex had chosen the food, asked for directions, and came to the clinic to find him because he wanted to. Heka had not arranged the evening behind his back. He hated that even a tiny part of him suspected his sister, but he needed to be sure.

“He remembered the sesame cakes,” he said, very quietly.

Heka’s fingers softly tightened once more around his wrist before she let go.

Without prompting, Haoyu began telling them about the evening. Heka listened while he described Rex standing in the doorway with supper, then his account of helping an old friend reach the ferry. Haoyu was smiling again by the time he mentioned the mule.

“He tried to leave out the part where he fell down the bank,” Haoyu said.

“Of course he did,” Weiyun replied, amused.

“He said he wasn’t hurt. And apparently the mule reached the ferry in better spirits than he did.”

Heka laughed, but her expression softened when Haoyu looked down at the key still resting between his fingers.

“He told me he’d been thinking about telling me on the way back,” Haoyu added. “Before he came to the clinic.”

“Had you asked him about the journey?” Heka asked gently.

Haoyu shook his head. “I didn’t know he’d gone.”

For a moment, neither woman said anything. Haoyu turned the key over, remembering the way Rex had looked at him across the table.

“And he remembered one of my patients,” he continued. “The older woman I was worried about. When I told him her grandson had made the paper crane, he asked whether she was the same person.”

“You’d mentioned her to him before?” Weiyun asked.

“I mentioned her once as a side thought. I didn’t realise he remembered.”

Heka reached for the teapot and filled his cup while he went on. Rex had asked about the carpenter’s recent contributions to the clinic, listened to him talk about his patients, and somehow emptied and refilled his tea without Haoyu noticing. Later, he tried to do it again while both cups were still full.

“I think he needed something to do with his hands,” Haoyu admitted, smiling into his own cup. “I wasn’t much better.”

Weiyun smiled at that. Beside her, Heka pressed her lips together, visibly resisting the urge to interrupt.

“And he wants to come tomorrow,” Haoyu said.

“What did you say?” Heka asked.

“Yes.” He hesitated. “I told him he could stay as long as he liked.”

“Seems you’ve finally figured out how to make yourself clear,” Weiyun observed.

Haoyu’s face warmed. “I didn’t mean to say it quite so bluntly..”

“Would you prefer him to stay for less time?” Wei teased with a smirk.

“No.”

“Then I think you managed very well.” She patted him on the shoulder.

He laughed softly, looking down at his hands. The quiet physical affection from the two women grounding him in the moment. Heka waited until the smile had settled before asking whether there was something else.

Haoyu turned the key between his fingers.

“It’s silly…and nothing in the grand scheme of things….When I handed him his basket, our hands touched.”

Neither woman interrupted him, but they both leaned in ever so slightly.

“He didn’t move away,” Haoyu continued. “And I—I quite deliberately let mine nudge against his for a moment.”

Heka’s expression became so tender that he had to look away from it.

“That sounds lovely,” she said. Haoyu swears he could hear her squealing in delight in her head..

“It was.” The admission left him quiet for a while. Then the practical anxieties, temporarily overwhelmed by happiness, began returning.

“I don’t know what I should do tomorrow.”

“Ask him how his day went,” Weiyun said. “Offer him tea. You’ve never had much difficulty finding something to ask him before.”

“It was easier when I knew what I was doing.”

Heka raised an eyebrow, and Haoyu gave her a faintly embarrassed smile.

“Or I thought I knew what I was doing,” he conceded. “I could bring something, ask where he’d been, and let him talk. Now I can’t help wondering whether he’ll expect something different.”

“From what you’ve told us, he enjoyed talking to you,” Weiyun replied. “And he asked about your day. You can tell him more of it tomorrow.”

“I don’t always have very much to say.”

“You’ve just spent quite some time telling us about two cups of tea,” Heka pointed out, smiling. “I’ve enjoyed every word.”

Haoyu laughed and finally relaxed back into his chair.

Heka leaned her elbow on the table, her voice gentle. “You’re allowed to want his company without inventing all the ways you have to earn it.”

He looked at her.

“He came to see you,” she continued. “You can let that be something he wanted and not some idea you had to sneakily plant in his head.”

Weiyun nodded. “And you can let him be nervous. You don’t have to make everything effortless for him.” Her expression softened as Haoyu looked towards her. “I know you don’t want to mistake being missed for being wanted. Give him time to show you. He asked to come again tomorrow. Let him come, and see how you feel when you’re together.”

Haoyu thought of Rex standing in the doorway, looking at the basket as though he hoped it might provide instructions. He had been so surprised by the visit that he had barely allowed himself to consider what it had cost Rex to arrive.

“If he offers to help,” Weiyun added, “let him help.”

“Even if there isn’t much to do?”

“Especially then,” Heka said.

He laughed, and this time the tension left his shoulders with it.

They sat together a little longer, gossiping about boys, some of whom were right outside discussing the moon (probably). So used to being an “only” child, Haoyu was glad to have his twin back in his life.

09 The next evening

By late afternoon, Haoyu had moved the lamp twice.

The first position had been perfectly satisfactory. The second offered no measurable improvement. When he caught himself considering a third, he remembered Weiyun telling him that he did not need to make everything effortless and left it where it was.

He had finished with the last patient, put away the clean cloths, and checked the kettle when Rex knocked.

Haoyu opened the door.

“Good evening,” Rex said, he winced internally at the overly polite greeting.

“Yes.” Haoyu closed his eyes briefly, scolding himself for letting his nerves get the better of him. “I mean, good evening.”

Rex’s internal embarrassment shifted to something warmer hearing Haoyu sound as nervous as he felt. “I’m a little early.”

“That’s all right. Please come in.”

They both began speaking again as Rex crossed the threshold. Both stopped. Rex gestured for Haoyu to continue, and Haoyu discovered that he had forgotten what he had meant to say.

“Tea,” he managed. “Would you like some?”

“Please.”

At the table, Rex accepted the cup and drank before Haoyu could warn him. His expression changed by the smallest possible amount.

“It’s hot,” Haoyu said, too late.

Rex swallowed with dignity. “I should have expected that. Tea does tend to be hot.”

Haoyu looked down, smiling. “Maybe wait for it to cool a bit more..”

“A wise suggestion I’m inclined to follow.”

The small stumble made it easier to shift to the food still sitting in the basekt. Rex set his cup aside to cool and began unpacking. Halfway through, he placed a wrapped dish between them and glanced towards Haoyu.

“I wasn’t sure whether you preferred the mushrooms or the greens,” Rex said. “The woman at the stall recommended these.”

Haoyu looked at the food, then at him. “I like both.”

“That makes tomorrow easier.”

Rex paused, apparently hearing what he had said. Haoyu busied himself fetching another bowl, pleased enough that he needed a moment before answering.

“You can ask me, you know. You don’t have to guess blindly.”

“I’m beginning to realise that,” Rex replied.

They set out the food together, occasionally reaching for the same thing and drawing back with unnecessary care. Once, their hands came close over a bowl. Rex paused, and Haoyu became very interested in straightening the cloth beneath it.

It seemed impossible that they could have spent an entire evening together yesterday and still need to learn where to put their hands today.

“How was rehearsal?” Haoyu asked, remembering that that’s where Rex had been earlier.

Rex’s relief at a familiar subject was visible. He described a turn that had been causing trouble and the discussion about whether the movement or the spacing was at fault.

“The one near the end?” Haoyu asked. “When you change direction before the others?”

Rex looked at him. “You remember that?”

Haoyu regretted, for a moment, how thoroughly he had given himself away. “I’ve watched a few times.”

“You have.” Rex smiled into his cup. “Yes. That one.”

They spoke about the rehearsal for a while. Then Haoyu noticed that Rex had apparently come straight from the hall.

“You didn’t stop at the estate?”

Rex shook his head.

“You should have rested first.”

“I wanted to come here,” Rex said matter of factly. Then in a more teasing tone, “Besides, how often did you come straight to the rehearsal hall after working here all day?”

Haoyu couldn’t argue with that. Haoyu lowered his eyes. Rex adjusted his cup without drinking.

“Maybe we both need to remember to take time to rest.”

They ate quietly until Rex noticed something new on the wall. The shelf was much larger than its modest contents required, and it had been fitted with the care of a man determined to make a lasting contribution.

“The carpenter?” Rex asked.

Haoyu followed his gaze and sighed. “He said I had enough stools.”

“A sensible conclusion.”

“I agreed too quickly.”

Rex surveyed the six small jars sitting on the generous expanse of wood. “You could fit an impressive quantity of medicine there.”

“The thought has occurred to me.”

They laughed, and the evening began to settle around them. Rex looked at the shelf again.

“I stayed at an inn once where they could have used your carpenter. The landlord had put up a shelf above my bed, and every time someone shut the door, something fell off it.”

“Did you ask for another room?” Haoyu asked.

“There wasn’t one. He assured me it had never caused any trouble before.”

“Did anything else fall?”

Rex hesitated. “Eventually, the shelf.”

Haoyu set down his bowl, laughing. “Eventually?”

“I moved the bed after the second cup. Unfortunately, that put it against the door, which was how the argument started.”

“With the landlord?”

“With Soul. I left out the part where he came upstairs.”

“You have,” Haoyu agreed, smiling. “Start there.”

Rex did, although he had to go back a little further to explain why they had stopped at that particular inn. Haoyu listened while he described the rain, the landlord’s increasingly unconvincing reassurances, and Soul’s opinion of a room he could only enter sideways.

“Did you stay the whole night?” Haoyu asked when Rex finally paused.

“We’d already paid. I’m hardly in a position to let my hard earned coins go to waste.”

“Of course.”

“It was dry,” Rex said in their defence. “We’d spent most of the afternoon discovering how much that mattered.”

Haoyu smiled, picturing the two of them arriving soaked and relieved to find any vacancies at all. “Where was it?”

Rex described the road and the little settlement beside it. Haoyu asked another question, and this time Rex answered without losing his place in the story.

Rex reached for his tea, still smiling, and Haoyu found himself reluctant to let the conversation end. There were things he wanted to ask about the journey before the inn, and he suspected Rex could spend quite some time explaining how they had ended up on that road.

Then he remembered Rex choosing food without knowing which dish he preferred, and his pleased, unguarded remark about tomorrow.

“You don’t have to bring dinner every time you visit me in the evening.”

Rex looked up. The slight uncertainty in his face made Haoyu hurry to finish.

“I mean, you could just come to see me.”

Rex’s expression softened.

Haoyu pressed on before he lost his courage. “I could cook. Or we could decide when you get here. You don’t have to arrive with something.”

“I’d like that,” Rex said.

“The cooking?”

“Coming to see you.”

Haoyu looked down so quickly that Rex laughed under his breath, then became embarrassed by his own answer. For a while, they occupied themselves with finishing the food.

Afterward, Rex offered to help wash up.

Haoyu almost told him there was no need. He remembered Heka and Weiyun, however, and handed him a clean cloth instead. The clinic had not been arranged for two people to be able to move around the washing basin with any kind of ease. Haoyu was reminded of how little room there was when he turned and nearly walked into Rex.

“Sorry.”

“It’s all right.” Rex looked at him with gentle amusement. “You don’t need to apologise for needing to move.”

Haoyu laughed. “I’d hate for my clumsiness to cause you to be injured.”

“We’re managing.”

They finished without breaking anything and the clinic found itself in a tidied and respectable state. Haoyu dried his hands, then found himself reluctant to put away the cloth because it meant admitting there was nothing left to do.

Rex seemed in no hurry either.

“Would you like to stay a little longer?” Haoyu asked.

“Yes.”

The answer came so readily that Haoyu looked up. Rex smiled at him, shy now that he had answered, and followed him back to the table.

Before pouring more tea, Rex checked both cups.

Haoyu saw him do it. Their eyes met, and they began laughing again.

A little later, each started a question at the same time. They stopped, offered the other a turn, and discovered that neither could remember what he had wanted to ask.

It hardly seemed to matter. They had time to think of something else.

10 The same way home

Haoyu took his time finishing the last checks before closing the clinic for the night. When he appeared in the doorway, Rex was still waiting outside, the empty basket swinging lightly from his hand as he paced along the lane. Rex stopped and turned towards him.

“You didn’t have to wait,” Haoyu said, pausing with his hand on the padlock.

Rex looked mildly puzzled. “We’re walking home, aren’t we?”

“Yes.” Haoyu glanced down at the lock, trying not to show quite how pleased he was. He had known they would be going in the same direction; he simply hadn’t wanted to presume that Rex would wait for him. “We are.”

Outside, the village had settled into its quieter hours. The last stalls were closed, and light showed through the windows of houses where people were still eating or talking. Haoyu locked the clinic, checked the latch, and fell into step beside Rex.

Walking made maintaining conversation easier. They could look ahead while speaking, and a pause did not require either of them to decide what expression to wear. Haoyu found himself remembering a question he had meant to ask over supper.

“Why *were* you and Soul on that road in the first place?”

Rex glanced towards him. “The inn?”

Haoyu nodded. “You explained how you found it. Why you were there, in that area, was glossed over.”

“We were taking a parcel to someone Soul knew. It should have been a straightforward journey, which is largely why I decided to tag along.”

“Should have been…” Haoyu couldn’t help but smile knowing the chaos that Rex has an uncanny ability to attract. “What went so wrong??”

“We stopped to ask directions.”

Haoyu waited. Rex looked at him and smiled.

“You don’t seem surprised,” Rex said this plainly, though a hint of his surprise came through. He was coming to realize exactly how much attention Haoyu had really been giving him.

“I didn’t say anything.”

Looking at him with a knowing grin, Rex continued, “The man we asked suggested a shorter route. Unfortunately, he assumed we could tell apart identical trees at seemingly identical crossings…”

“And yet you still chose to follow the route?”

“We were *very* confident when we set off.”

Haoyu laughed softly. Rex adjusted the basket in his hand and went on to describe where they had taken the wrong crossing. This time, Haoyu could follow the journey properly: the fork they should have passed, the crossing they had reached instead, and the long stretch of road where the rain finally caught them.

“Did the parcel arrive dry at least?” Haoyu asked.

“Perfectly dry,” Rex said, with some satisfaction. “We’d wrapped it properly.”

“Just not yourselves.”

“Our preparations favoured the parcel, of course.”

Haoyu laughed, and their sleeves brushed as the path narrowed.

Neither moved very far away.

For several steps, they said nothing. Haoyu could hear the basket handle shift against Rex’s palm. He was suddenly aware that, although they had taken this road many times separately, they had never walked it quite like this.

“I thought I would be less nervous tonight,” Rex admitted suddenly. His voice was soft and gave a glimpse to a vulnerability he rarely let show.

Haoyu turned, shifting his gaze more fully towards him. “So did I.”

“I knew exactly what I was going to say when you opened the door.”

“You said good evening.”

“There was more.” Rex looked down at the path, his smile faint. “Then you were there, and it all became rather difficult to remember.”

Haoyu’s face warmed. He was grateful for the darkness beyond the lanterns.

“I answered yes.”

Rex laughed softly. “I liked that you seemed pleased to see me.”

Haoyu let the words settle before he answered. “I was.”

At the bridge, they paused beside the railing. Water moved beneath them in dark folds, catching the light where it passed the houses along the bank. Rex set the basket down briefly and rested his hands on the wood.

“I like the clinic,” Rex said.

Haoyu looked towards him. “It isn’t very exciting.”

“Your carpenter seems determined to change that.”

Haoyu smiled. “I’m almost afraid to find out what he’ll bring next.”

“So am I. I’d like to be there when he brings it.”

Rex was smiling too, but his expression grew more thoughtful as he looked back towards the water.

“I liked seeing the paper crane,” he added. “And hearing about the little boy who made it. When you mention him again, I’ll know who you mean.”

Haoyu rested his hands on the railing beside him. He had spent so much time learning the names in Rex’s stories that he had scarcely considered what it would feel like to have Rex learn his.

“You’ll probably hear about him quite often then.”

“I’d like that.” Rex turned towards him. “You’re a great listener, but I find I’m very keen to listen to your stories. Almost more than I enjoy telling my own.”

Haoyu had no practiced reply for that. He looked out over the water until he could trust his voice.

“It’s nice having company after the patients leave.” Haoyu glanced at him, then made himself finish. “Your company.”

Rex lowered his eyes, smiling. His fingers shifted on the railing, close to Haoyu’s, though neither quite closed the distance.

When the cool air finally persuaded them to continue, Rex picked up the basket and fell into step beside Haoyu. The rest of the walk passed more quietly, with occasional remarks about things they saw and longer stretches when neither seemed to need a reason to fill the silence.

Once they reached the main gate of the estate, Rex slowed. Voices carried from inside, and a lantern still burned near the main hall.

“Do you think everyone is still awake?” Haoyu asked, more quietly than necessary.

“Probably some of them.” Rex had lowered his voice too.

They stood for a moment, listening. Then Rex looked at the gate, at Haoyu, and back at the gate.

“We are standing outside our own home whispering. Anyone passing would think we were planning to rob it.”

Haoyu pressed a hand over his mouth. Rex began laughing, and that settled the matter. They went in together.

Nobody stopped them. Somebody called a greeting from farther down the walkway, and they answered it as normally as they could. At the junction where their paths divided, Haoyu slowed again.

His courtyard lay in one direction. Rex’s was at the opposite end.

“Well,” Haoyu said.

“I could walk you to your gate,” Rex offered.

Haoyu looked toward Rex’s side of the lodge. “But your courtyard is on the opposite end…”

“I know.”

The answer came with a small, almost apologetic smile. Haoyu felt his own answering it.

“All right.”

They continued together beneath the covered walkway. The extra distance was not long, but Haoyu cherished it absurdly. At his gate, he fumbled with the door while Rex waited beside him.

“Tomorrow?” Rex asked.

“Do you have rehearsal?”

“Yes. But I can come after.”

They said goodnight, then remained facing each other for another moment. Eventually, Haoyu opened the gate. Rex waited until he had stepped through before turning away.

Haoyu looked back.

Rex, only a few paces down the path, looked back too. They exchanged a small, embarrassed smile, and Haoyu lifted his hand.

He stayed at the gate until Rex turned the corner.

11 A week at Revelry Hall

Over the next few weeks, the clinic acquired a second evening life.

On three or four nights out of every seven, Rex arrived after the patients had gone. Sometimes he brought supper. Sometimes Haoyu had already arranged it. Once or twice, they discovered that both had brought enough for two and sat down to a meal that required considerable determination to finish.

They learned each other's habits in small pieces. Rex came to recognise when Haoyu needed a few quiet minutes to finish his notes. Haoyu learned that an unusually quiet arrival sometimes meant Rex had spent the day on the road and would be more inclined to talk once he had eaten.

There were evenings when Rex was away altogether. He still took work that carried him beyond the city and visited people he had known long before joining the Wet Noodles. Now, when he mentioned an upcoming journey, he usually told Haoyu how long he expected it to take.

"I should be back the following afternoon," Rex said once, lingering beside the clinic door. "Would you be here that evening?"

Haoyu looked up from the wash cloths he was folding. "I should."

"Then perhaps we could eat together."

"I'd like that."

Rex smiled and finally left. Haoyu finished folding the cloth in his hands before noticing that he had put it on the wrong pile.

When Rex returned, Haoyu had questions waiting. He wanted to know whether the journey had gone as planned, whether the friend Rex had mentioned was well, and occasionally whether a story truly required such an unlikely number of unfortunate coincidences. Rex answered with varying degrees of dignity.

He had questions of his own now, too. He asked after patients Haoyu had mentioned and remembered to enquire whether the carpenter had appeared

with anything else. Sometimes Haoyu began telling him about the day before they had finished setting out supper.

On quieter evenings, Rex washed bowls, moved a stool when it was in the way, or read while Haoyu finished work. There was no longer any need to account for every silence. When they had arranged to eat together, Haoyu began setting out the second cup before he heard the knock.

At home, the people who loved them noticed.

Heka sometimes asked, privately, whether her brother had eaten well. The question itself was entirely innocent until she smiled. Soul observed that Rex had become remarkably efficient at leaving rehearsal, then allowed the subject to drop when Rex looked at him with obvious alarm.

There was teasing, but it was gentle and kept to places where neither man had to become a spectacle. Nobody followed them to the clinic. Nobody turned their suppers into a group outing. The walks back to the estate remained theirs, and Rex's extra journey to Haoyu's gate became so regular that neither mentioned the distance anymore.

As the next Wet Noodles performance approached, Fae confirmed the arrangements for the final week of rehearsals at Revelry Hall.

Heka came to the clinic with a request and an earnest expression that made Haoyu set down his brush.

"Would you be able to help us at Revelry Hall next week?"

"As a medic I'm guessing?"

"Yes. There will be people moving scenery, people rehearsing, and people insisting that they can lift things they absolutely cannot lift. I would feel much better if someone sensible were there."

"You're there."

"I said someone sensible."

He smiled despite himself. Heka rested her hands on the edge of his table.

“Every evening for the last week of rehearsals, if you can arrange it. Fae has a space in mind for you already and we can adjust to your needs.” She glanced towards his open ledger. “I know you have patients to think about. We can work out the hours before you agree.”

Haoyu considered his appointments. With enough notice, he could see the regular patients earlier and make arrangements for anything that needed attention after he left. Heka waited while he worked through the practicalities, her expression growing increasingly hopeful.

“All right,” he said.

She brightened immediately, came around the table to hug him, and stayed to work out the hours.

On the first evening, Haoyu arrived carrying his medicine bag and feeling strangely conspicuous. He knew everyone. He had visited rehearsals before. Yet he was aware, as he entered the hall, that he was arriving somewhere Rex belonged and that their familiar private routine would be visible to other people.

Rex saw him almost at once.

The smile came before either of them remembered to be self-conscious.

“Have you eaten?” Rex asked, coming toward him.

“Not yet.”

“There’s food set aside. I thought you might come straight from the clinic.”

He took Haoyu’s bag as naturally as he had begun taking things from him at the end of their evenings. Haoyu thanked him, then noticed Fae approaching. Rex appeared to remember at the same instant that they were standing in the middle of a very busy room.

Fae glanced at the bag and indicated a table near the side of the hall.

“We’ve cleared that space for you. Let me know if you need anything else.”

Then she returned to a discussion about timing, leaving them both to recover from an embarrassment nobody else seemed particularly interested in causing.

At the table, Haoyu found a cup of warm tea.

Rex set down the bag. “It should still be drinkable.”

Haoyu looked at him. “Thank you.”

For a moment, it felt just like the clinic. Then someone called Rex back, and both of them looked away with matching smiles.

Haoyu soon had enough to occupy him. There were small scrapes, tired feet, and one person who had ignored a developing discomfort until it became impossible to pretend it was improving. He attended to them with the competence that usually deserted him only when Rex asked an unexpectedly tender question.

Baoyu came to request another clean cloth. DFBB asked whether the table was in a convenient place. Neither turned the visit into an occasion for commentary, and Haoyu found himself relaxing.

On the second evening, Rex brought him a plate during a break and stayed to complain quietly about a change Fae had made. Haoyu knew enough about the rehearsal by then to ask whether the change actually helped.

“Yes,” Rex admitted. “That makes it much harder to complain.”

Haoyu was laughing when Gong called Rex back to the floor. Both men straightened, suddenly conscious of how close they had been sitting. Gong merely repeated the instruction and went to find his own place.

By the fourth evening, there was a spare stool beside Haoyu’s table. Rex sat there whenever the break was long enough. Once, as he reached for his tea, Haoyu caught the loose edge of his sleeve before it dragged across the cup and retied it without thinking.

Rex held still for him.

Only afterward did they look up and remember the room around them.

“I keep forgetting,” Haoyu murmured.

Rex looked down at the neat fastening. “So do I.”

Across the hall, Heka was arguing cheerfully about a practical detail with someone carrying a lantern. Fae was reviewing the next sequence. Their friends had things to do and, to Haoyu's immense relief, were allowing him and Rex to do the same.

As the week went on, the moments of self-consciousness grew shorter. Rex began asking whether Haoyu wanted anything when the others went for food. Haoyu handed him water without first checking who might be watching. Their conversations still softened when they were alone at the side of the room, but they no longer broke off entirely whenever someone passed.

On the final rehearsal night, Rex returned to the table flushed from the last run and asked what Haoyu had thought.

"The turn is better," Haoyu said. "You don't have to think about it anymore."

Rex smiled, visibly pleased. "I wondered whether you'd notice."

"I was watching."

Haoyu had answered without hesitation. Only when Rex's smile softened did he become conscious of how readily he had admitted it. The answer made them both quiet for a moment.

"I've liked having you here," Rex said at last.

"I've liked being here."

"Even with everyone?"

Haoyu glanced around the hall. "Yes." He smiled a little. "Although I miss our suppers."

"The quiet ones."

"Yes."

Rex nodded, looking down at his cup. "So do I."

When they packed up, Rex hesitated before reaching for Haoyu's bag. Heka and several of the others stood nearby. Haoyu saw the hesitation and moved the bag toward him.

"Thank you," he said.

Rex took it, smiling.

Heka thanked her brother for the week and wished them both goodnight.

Haoyu had also agreed to attend the performance as the physician on hand. Before leaving, he checked with Fae that his table could remain where it was and confirmed when she needed him to arrive.

They left together while the others continued gathering their things, and on the walk home they agreed to have supper at the clinic again after the performance was over.

The performance itself passed in music, movement, and the bright energy of a room full of people. Haoyu had responsibilities that kept him from watching every moment, but he saw enough. Once, when Rex looked toward the side of the hall between sequences, Haoyu was there to smile at him.

Afterward came congratulations, work, and more people than either of them could easily escape. Their promised quiet evening would have to wait until the following day.

12 A restorative evening

The following evening, the last patient had barely disappeared down the lane when Rex arrived at the clinic with supper and the expression of a man who had suffered beyond reasonable endurance.

Haoyu looked up from his table.

Rex came inside, set the basket down with great care, and walked directly to the cot in the corner. He removed his boots, lowered himself onto it, and collapsed backward with a dramatic sigh.

“I have come to be pitied.”

Haoyu stared at him for a moment before laughter overtook concern.

“What happened?”

“Fae.”

“Was the meeting difficult?”

“It was long.” Rex arranged one arm over his eyes. “The performance is over. I had allowed myself to believe we might enjoy that fact briefly.”

“And instead?”

“We reviewed it.”

Haoyu brought him water. Rex lowered his arm to accept it and sat up enough to drink.

“She said it would be brief,” he continued. “Then there was another scroll. Then future plans.”

“That sounds useful.”

“There were several futures.”

Haoyu laughed and sat on the stool beside the cot. “Did she at least say the performance went well?”

“Yes.” Rex sighed. “She was very pleased. She also had excellent ideas, which made it impossible to object. I simply would have appreciated hearing some of them after more sleep.”

“Have you eaten?”

“A little.”

Haoyu looked toward the basket.

“That is supper,” Rex confirmed. “I was determined to get here before I became entirely unreasonable.”

“Then we should probably eat it.”

Rex considered the effort involved, then held out the empty cup. “You make a compelling argument.”

By the time the food was on the table, his exhaustion had become less theatrical. He still complained, but between complaints he described the meeting with enough detail for Haoyu to see why Fae had wanted it. There had been things worth celebrating and things worth improving. Rex simply wished the celebration had included a longer interval in which nobody asked him to remember exactly what had happened during the second half.

His imitation of Fae consulting her notes was affectionate and sufficiently accurate that Haoyu nearly laughed into his bowl.

“She’ll hear about this,” Haoyu warned.

Rex looked wounded. “I came expecting kindness.”

“You’ve had water, supper, and a cot.”

“And now threats.”

They finished eating in much the same way they had on so many evenings, with Rex gradually recovering and Haoyu feeling the quiet pleasure of having him there again. The hall had been exciting. He had enjoyed seeing Rex in the midst of something that mattered to him. Still, he had missed being able to listen without somebody calling either of them away.

After they cleaned up, Haoyu told Rex to rest for a little while before they walked home. Rex returned to the cot and sat with his back comfortably against the wall, leaving room beside him.

Haoyu looked at the space, then at Rex.

“You can sit,” Rex said, softly enough that it sounded like an invitation rather than a joke.

Haoyu did.

For a while, they talked about the evening before. Rex asked whether Haoyu had managed to see the final sequence, and Haoyu described the part he had watched from beside his table. He was halfway through recalling something when he noticed that Rex had grown unusually quiet.

“What is it?” Haoyu asked.

Rex looked down at his hands, then back at him.

“During the meeting, I kept thinking about coming here. I wanted to sit with you without someone calling one of us away.”

Haoyu smiled. “I missed this too.”

“I know. You said so.”

Rex’s answering smile was small and nervous. He shifted beside him, turning enough that Haoyu could see his face properly.

“I’ve been thinking about what I wanted to say when I got here,” Rex admitted. “Instead, I’ve spent far too much time complaining about Fae.”

“I didn’t mind.”

“I’m glad.” Rex paused. “But there is something else.”

Haoyu’s fingers tightened together in his lap. He waited while Rex took a breath.

“I look forward to these evenings,” Rex said. “When I’m away, I find things I want to tell you. When I’m here, I keep finding reasons to stay a little longer.” His face

warmed, but he held Haoyu's gaze. "I don't want to leave you guessing about why....I want to court you."

Haoyu stopped breathing for a moment.

"Properly," Rex continued. "I like you very much, and I want you to be certain of that."

The room seemed suddenly very quiet. Haoyu could hear the small sounds beyond the shutters and the soft shift of Rex's sleeve when he moved his hand. He had imagined words like these often enough that hearing them aloud required a moment of adjustment.

"Yes," he said.

Rex's expression opened, hopeful and almost disbelieving.

Haoyu hurried to make himself clear. "Very much. I would like to keep courting you too."

Rex looked at him, his expression softening. He had thought back over those early visits often enough since speaking to Soul and Gong. Hearing Haoyu confirm what he had meant still left Rex briefly at a loss.

"You really were," Rex said quietly.

"I was."

Rex lowered his gaze with a rueful smile. "I did a remarkably poor job of noticing."

Haoyu's answering smile was affectionate. "Yes. You did."

They laughed quietly. Then Haoyu drew a breath and said the words he had spent so long trying to express in other ways.

"I like you, Rex. I have for quite a while."

Rex looked back at him.

"I'm glad you still do."

Haoyu placed his hand on the cot between them. Their little fingers touched. This time, he did not withdraw after the moment had passed; he turned his hand slightly, offering it openly.

Rex took it.

They adjusted their fingers with the shy care of people discovering something they had wanted for a long time. Rex's thumb moved against his hand, then paused. Haoyu squeezed gently, and the movement resumed.

"I had a longer explanation prepared," Rex admitted.

Haoyu looked down at their hands, smiling. "After the meeting you've had, I appreciate the shorter one."

Rex laughed, and for a while they stayed where they were, their hands joined between them. Eventually, Haoyu glanced at the lamp.

"We should probably go home."

"Probably," Rex agreed, making no immediate attempt to move.

Haoyu smiled. He gave Rex's hand one last gentle squeeze before releasing it and standing. While he checked the room, Rex put on his boots and collected the basket.

Outside, Haoyu locked the door while Rex shifted the basket into his other hand. When Haoyu turned back, Rex offered his free hand without trying to make it look accidental.

Haoyu took it.

They began the walk home more slowly than usual. There was plenty they could have said, but for the first part of the journey both seemed content to discover how it felt to walk like this. Rex looked down at their hands once, then again a little later.

"Checking?" Haoyu asked.

Rex glanced at him, blushing. "A little."

Haoyu squeezed his fingers.

At the bridge, they stopped without letting go. The village lights moved on the surface of the water, and the evening air was cool enough to make standing close pleasant for more than one reason.

“How long?” Rex asked after a while.

Haoyu looked toward him.

“Have you liked me?” Rex clarified, then immediately appeared to regret asking so directly.

Haoyu considered finding a less embarrassing answer. Instead, he looked out over the water and told him the truth.

“The first rehearsal Heka brought me to was rather an impactful evening for me.”

Rex was silent for a moment.

“That early?”

Haoyu nodded. “More like a vague crush at first. But it grew from there.”

Rex looked down at their hands. “I wish I’d understood sooner.”

Haoyu moved a little closer until their shoulders touched.

“I’m happy you understand now.”

Rex turned toward him. This time, Haoyu managed to keep looking back. The colour rose in both their faces, but neither seemed willing to give up the moment.

“So am I,” Rex said.

When they reached the estate gate, voices were still audible from inside. Rex glanced at their joined hands, then at Haoyu, leaving the choice with him.

Haoyu tightened his fingers.

“Come on.”

They entered together.

Nobody stopped them or demanded an explanation. The familiar paths lay ahead, and Rex took the turn toward Haoyu's courtyard as he had on so many evenings. At the gate, he put down the basket, though there was no practical reason to do so unless he intended to stay another moment.

"You should get some rest," Haoyu told him. "You arrived at the clinic near death."

Rex smiled. "I've had a very restorative evening."

Haoyu laughed, then looked down when Rex's thumb brushed his knuckles again.

"Thank you for letting me come," Rex said.

"You can come any time you'd like."

"I will probably like to come very often."

There was no need, now, to wonder whether the words were only friendliness. Haoyu knew what Rex meant. He knew what he meant in return.

Still holding his hand, he stepped closer and rested his forehead briefly against Rex's shoulder. Rex drew a small, surprised breath. Then his free hand came to rest lightly against Haoyu's upper back.

They stayed that way for several breaths, quiet beneath the lantern. When Haoyu straightened, Rex was as flushed as he was.

Their goodnights were soft. They released each other slowly, and Haoyu opened the gate.

Before going to his door, he looked back. Rex was still there, smiling at him.

This time, Haoyu did not try to hide how happily he smiled in return.

13 A first at the clinic

In the evenings since they had agreed to court one another, Rex had begun offering his hand whenever they left the clinic. Haoyu no longer needed quite so much courage to take it, although he still found himself smiling at the road afterwards.

Tonight, the clinic had been closed for nearly an hour, and Rex had run out of washing up to help with. There had only been two bowls, which were washed, dried, and put away, along with everything else either of them had found a reason to attend to.

Now they sat beside one another at the little table, the supper basket packed beneath it. When Rex rested his hand palm-up between them, Haoyu slipped his own into it almost without thinking.

That part was becoming easier.

What remained difficult was looking up and discovering that Rex was watching him with the same quiet pleasure he felt himself.

“What?” Haoyu asked.

“Nothing.”

Rex’s thumb moved lightly over his knuckles. Haoyu looked down at their hands, already warming.

“You keep doing that.”

“Would you like me to stop?”

“No.”

The answer came quickly enough to make Rex smile. Haoyu caught it before he could look away, and for a moment they simply sat there, smiling at each other.

Then Rex glanced at his mouth.

It was brief. Haoyu might have missed it if he hadn’t been looking so closely.

His fingers tightened.

Rex's gaze returned to his eyes, and something changed in the small space between their chairs. Haoyu became acutely aware of how close they were: Rex's knee beside his own, the loose strands of pale hair against his cheek, the warm pressure of his hand.

"Oh," Haoyu said softly.

Rex went pink.

"I'm sorry. I was—"

He stopped, looked down at their joined hands, and took a breath.

"I was thinking about kissing you."

Haoyu's heart gave such a hard, immediate beat that he was grateful to be sitting down.

Rex waited. He had gone very still, except for the slight movement of his fingers against Haoyu's.

Haoyu knew he needed to say something. Preferably something more useful than *oh*.

"I would like that."

Rex looked up. "Yes?"

"Yes."

The second answer was quieter, but Haoyu managed to hold his gaze as he said it.

For a few seconds, neither of them moved.

Then Rex gave a small, helpless laugh and looked at the table. "I thought getting that far would help."

"It did." Haoyu laughed too, mostly from relief. His free hand had been resting in his lap; he lifted it and caught gently at Rex's sleeve.

Rex looked at the fingers holding his sleeve, then back at him.

Haoyu drew him a little closer.

Their chairs were already near enough that Rex only had to turn. He lifted his free hand slowly, giving Haoyu time to follow the movement, and rested his fingertips along his cheek.

Haoyu had imagined being touched like this, though he had never quite accounted for how difficult it would make breathing normally.

Rex's hand was warm. His expression had lost its uncertain smile, though the flush of colour remained high in his face. He looked at Haoyu so carefully that Haoyu's own nervousness softened for a moment.

He wanted Rex to know he was welcome.

So he leaned into the touch.

Rex came closer.

Their noses brushed, and both of them paused.

A small laugh escaped Haoyu.

"Sorry."

"No, I—"

Rex stopped, smiling now, his forehead almost touching Haoyu's.

They adjusted by the smallest amount.

Then Rex kissed him.

It was gentle, a little tentative: warm lips against his, a brief pressure that made Haoyu's fingers close more firmly around the fabric of Rex's sleeve.

For the first instant, he was too overwhelmed to do anything at all.

Then he kissed him back and felt Rex's breath catch.

The hand at his cheek settled more securely, and their joined hands shifted on the table as Rex turned closer. Haoyu forgot about the lamp, the washed bowls, the sounds coming faintly through the shutters. He knew where Rex's thumb rested beneath his cheekbone. He knew the softness of his mouth.

When they parted, it was only by a little.

Haoyu opened his eyes to find Rex was looking at him, flushed and very quiet.

Neither seemed quite ready to move away.

Haoyu became aware that he was still clutching Rex's sleeve. He loosened his fingers, smoothing the small creases he had made.

Rex watched the movement.

"Was that—"

"Yes," Haoyu said.

Rex blinked, then smiled.

"I hadn't finished."

"I know."

Haoyu lowered his gaze, mortified by how readily the answer had escaped him, but Rex's thumb brushed his cheek again.

"I liked it too," Rex said.

That brought his eyes back up.

The words were simple. Rex seemed almost shy of them, but he said them plainly, and Haoyu felt the last of his embarrassment give way to a happiness so immediate he couldn't contain his smile.

Rex smiled back.

Then Haoyu glanced at his mouth.

This time, Rex noticed.

“Oh,” he said.

Haoyu laughed softly.

“Yes. That.”

He let go of Rex’s sleeve and lifted his hand to the side of his face. A loose strand of hair caught beneath his fingers; he brushed it back carefully, buying himself one more moment.

Rex waited for him.

That was what finally made it possible.

Haoyu leaned forward and kissed him.

The second kiss was less hurried. He knew where to put his hand now, knew how close he wanted to be. Rex’s fingers slipped from his cheek to rest lightly at the back of his neck, and Haoyu moved nearer until their knees pressed together beneath the table.

There was still a little uncertainty in it. A pause, a change of angle, a smile neither quite managed to suppress.

Haoyu found that he liked those things too.

When they drew apart, he stayed close enough to rest his forehead against Rex’s.

For a while, all he could hear was their breathing.

Then Rex murmured, “I’m going to have difficulty leaving tonight.”

Haoyu closed his eyes, smiling.

“You don’t have to leave yet.”

“I know.”

Rex’s hand moved gently against the back of his neck.

“I’m trying to remember that eventually we should.”

Haoyu laughed and leaned back enough to look at him. Rex's hair was a little disturbed where his fingers had passed through it. Without thinking, he smoothed it into place.

Rex caught his hand before he could withdraw it and held it against his cheek for a moment.

The tenderness of that nearly undid him more than the kisses.

"You're very red," Rex said softly.

Haoyu looked at him. "So are you."

"I know. I can feel it."

They laughed together, and Rex gently released the hand he had been holding against his cheek. Haoyu let it settle on Rex's sleeve, still reluctant to move very far away.

The familiar sound helped Haoyu settle. This was still Rex, who could spend half a supper describing a journey and only admit under questioning that he had taken the wrong road. He remembered which cakes Haoyu liked. He asked about his patients and listened to the answers. Haoyu knew how to tease him, how to make him comfortable after a tiring day, and how easily an evening could pass in his company.

Now he knew what it felt like to kiss him, too.

He glanced at Rex and found him smiling back. There would be time to grow familiar with this.

Eventually, Rex moved his chair closer.

Haoyu let their shoulders rest against each other and turned their joined hands over in his lap.

The lamp still had plenty of oil.

They stayed a little longer.

14 An invitation home

Several evenings after their first kiss, Rex stopped at Haoyu's courtyard gate as he always did.

He shifted the empty supper basket into his other hand while Haoyu found his key, then remembered something he had meant to tell him on the walk. Haoyu turned back to listen, smiling, with the key still resting against the lock. He had become very good at finding reasons to postpone this part of the evening.

Then came the familiar pause.

Usually, one of them would say goodnight. Rex would linger until Haoyu went through the gate, and Haoyu would find a reason to look back before closing it.

Tonight, he turned the key but left the gate shut.

"Would you like to come in?"

Rex's expression changed so quickly that Haoyu felt his own face warm.

"For a while," he added. "If you're not tired."

"I'm not tired."

The answer was immediate. Rex glanced down at the basket, then back at him.

"I'd like to."

Haoyu nodded and opened the gate, grateful that he could turn away for a moment. He had been thinking about asking since they left the clinic. Somewhere along the lane, he had prepared a perfectly ordinary explanation involving tea and the pleasant evening.

Apparently, none of it had been necessary.

He stepped aside to let Rex through.

The courtyard was small, with a narrow planted bed along one wall and several pots gathered where they caught the morning sun. Beneath the eaves stood a low table and a wooden bench, its cushion pushed to one end. A book lay

facedown beside it, marking the place where Haoyu had abandoned his reading that morning.

Rex stopped a few steps inside while Haoyu closed the gate.

Glancing around, Haoyu became aware of everything all at once: the broom leaning against the wall, a cloth he had left drying over a rail, untidy growths in several of the pots. He wished he had straightened the cushions that morning. Then he wondered why that should matter when Rex had already seen his clinic at the end of several particularly difficult days.

Still, this was where he came when his work was finished. The book was one he read for pleasure. The plants were arranged where he liked to see them from the bench. He had spent more evenings than he cared to admit sitting here and thinking about Rex.

Now Rex was standing a few steps away, looking around with quiet interest, and Haoyu wanted him to like being here.

“Let me light the lantern.”

He busied himself beneath the eaves, then gathered up the book. By the time he turned around, Rex had set the basket neatly beside the door.

“Here?” Rex asked, indicating the bench.

“Yes, of course.”

Haoyu immediately wondered whether *of course* had sounded strange. Rex could hardly be expected to know where he liked people to sit.

But Rex only smiled and sat down.

“I’ll get some tea.”

“Haoyu.”

He stopped in the doorway.

“You can sit down first.”

Rex said it gently, with enough amusement that Haoyu knew he had noticed.

“I’m not usually like this.”

“I know.”

That answer, and the warmth with which it was given, made Haoyu feel considerably more foolish and considerably more at ease.

He fetched a second cushion from inside, put it beside Rex’s, and sat down.

For several breaths they looked out into the courtyard together.

Then Rex reached for his hand.

Haoyu let out a quiet breath and turned his palm upward to meet him.

“There,” Rex said.

Haoyu glanced at him. “There?”

Rex looked down at their hands, suddenly less certain of his own composure.

“I thought it might help.”

“It does.”

They settled closer, their sleeves resting together on the bench. Beyond the wall, footsteps passed along the lodge walkway, accompanied by a short burst of conversation. Haoyu recognized one of the voices, but the sound continued past the gate and faded toward another courtyard.

Rex’s thumb moved once over the side of his hand.

“Do you sit out here often?”

“When the weather’s good. Sometimes I read.”

Rex glanced at the book Haoyu had moved to the table. “What is it?”

“An account of someone’s travels. Weiyun lent it to me.”

“Where did they go?” Rex asked.

Haoyu described the stretch he was reading. Partway through, Rex glanced towards the book again.

“I’ve been along that road.”

“Have you?” Haoyu turned more fully towards him. “There’s a crossing the writer spends several pages complaining about.”

Rex smiled. “Then I probably know the one.”

“You’ll have to tell me whether the account is fair.”

“I’d like to read it first. He may have had a much easier time than I did.”

Haoyu laughed and looked towards the book himself. “I haven’t made much progress lately.”

“Too busy?”

Haoyu looked down.

“Sometimes.”

Rex waited, and Haoyu could feel the smile he was trying not to turn toward him.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You’re doing it again.”

“Doing what?”

“Waiting for me to say something embarrassing.”

Rex laughed softly. “I wasn’t. But now I’m interested.”

Haoyu rubbed his thumb along the seam of Rex’s sleeve. It was easier to speak while looking at that.

“Sometimes I come back and sit here for a while before going to bed.”

“All right.”

“And I think about the evening.”

Rex's fingers grew still around his.

Haoyu finally looked up. Rex had stopped smiling quite so broadly, though the pleasure remained in his expression. He was watching him with that particular attentiveness Haoyu was still learning to bear.

"With me?" he asked.

Haoyu nodded.

A faint blush rose into Rex's cheeks.

"I do that too."

For a moment, Haoyu could picture it: Rex on the other side of the lodge, finally alone in his rooms, remembering the same conversation, the same walk, the same reluctant goodnight.

He had known Rex cared for him. Rex had told him plainly, and kissed him, and returned the following evening with an expression that had made Haoyu forget what he was about to say.

Somehow, this pleased him just as much.

"What do you think about?" he asked.

Rex gave him a look.

Haoyu smiled. "Now I'm interested."

"That seems fair."

Rex considered his answer, looking out toward the plants. Haoyu waited.

"Lately," Rex said, "I've been wondering whether I should have kissed you again before I left."

Haoyu's face warmed so abruptly that Rex began to laugh.

"Now you've made me say it."

"I didn't know you were going to say that."

“What were you expecting?”

“I don’t know.”

Haoyu looked at him for another moment, then let his gaze fall briefly to Rex’s mouth. His face was still warm, but this time he managed to say what he wanted.

“You could kiss me now.”

Rex’s smile softened. “I was hoping I might.”

Haoyu caught gently at his sleeve as Rex turned towards him. They leaned closer together, and Haoyu met him halfway.

He still felt that startling rush of happiness. He wondered how many times Rex would have to kiss him before it stopped surprising him quite so much.

Perhaps a great many.

He was willing to find out.

When they parted, Rex remained close. Haoyu could see the slight uncertainty return to his expression, as though he, too, was deciding what happened next.

So Haoyu kissed him again.

It was brief, and a little less carefully managed. Rex made a soft, surprised sound against his mouth, then smiled so much that Haoyu had to draw back, laughing.

“What?”

“Nothing,” Rex said.

“Rex.”

“I’m happy.”

The simplicity of it left Haoyu quiet.

Rex looked down at their hands.

“I keep wanting to say that. Even if it’s beginning to feel repetitive.”

Haoyu leaned closer until his shoulder rested fully against Rex’s.

“I like hearing it.”

They stayed that way for a while. Somewhere beyond the courtyard, a door closed. The lantern moved faintly in the evening breeze, shifting its light across the table and the abandoned book.

Eventually, Haoyu remembered his offer of tea.

This time, when he stood, Rex let him go without looking concerned that he might find six more things to tidy. Haoyu brought out the tray, and Rex moved the book aside to make room.

They drank slowly, talking about ordinary things. Rex asked which plants Haoyu had brought home from the clinic and which he had chosen simply because he liked them. Haoyu admitted that one pot contained something he could no longer identify because Heka had given it to him with instructions to keep it alive and no further explanation.

Rex examined it from the bench.

“It appears to be doing well.”

“That’s what I tell her.”

“Does she know what it is?”

“I’ve begun to suspect she doesn’t.”

Rex laughed, and Haoyu found himself watching him.

He liked the sound here.

He liked Rex’s basket beside his door and his hand resting near the tea tray. He liked being able to turn and find him within reach.

When the night grew cooler, they moved closer together without discussing it. Rex put an arm around him, tentatively at first, and Haoyu settled against his

side. There was a small adjustment of sleeves, a quiet inquiry about whether he was comfortable, and then they were still.

Haoyu rested his head against Rex's shoulder.

After a while, he felt Rex's cheek touch his hair.

Neither said anything.

By the time they finally rose, the tea had long since cooled. Rex picked up the basket while Haoyu carried the tray inside, and they met again at the gate.

"I'd like you to come here again," Haoyu said.

Rex's smile appeared before he answered.

"I'd like that very much."

"You don't have to wait for an evening at the clinic."

Rex glanced back toward the bench, then at him.

"All right."

Haoyu reached for his hand once more.

"And I would like to see your courtyard sometime."

"Yes," Rex said, then laughed under his breath at his own eagerness. "Yes. You should."

They exchanged a last, shy kiss beside the gate. Rex left with his basket and an entirely unsuccessful attempt to stop smiling, and Haoyu closed the gate behind him.

Before going to bed, he returned to extinguish the lantern.

The second cushion had shifted close against his own. Haoyu straightened its edge, then set the borrowed book on the table.

He left the cushions together.